

pool of purebreds has broken down so much over the years (because it's so "pure"), that each breed is known for specific health problems. This results in more vet bills and an animal that often has a shorter life span.

One of my favorite ways to support pet adoption is to go to the local humane society and find a fur-baby his or her forever home. Fees hover around the \$50 mark depending on size or type of animal, and many shelters will start you off with supplies and a bag of food. It's much harder to know the past history or heritage of an adopted pet, especially if they are over a year old, but saving a pet from homelessness gives you that warm, fuzzy feeling you can't get anywhere else!

You can also check Craigslist for pets in need of a loving home. Many owners find that they can't care for their pet anymore, and are willing to give or charge a small fee to rehome them. Most come with their own supplies, so it's an inexpensive way to adopt a pet and find out a little bit more about their past history.

3. KEEP THEM HEALTHY

A healthy pet is less prone to emergency vet visits (and therefore, bills), so do what you can to make sure your pet stays in stellar shape. Get the proper amount of exercise for the size and age of your dog, and be careful about slipping Fido scraps from the dinner table. Grooming regularly, trimming nails, and keeping teeth clean all add up and make a difference too.

You'll also want to stay current on all shots and prevention meds. It's much cheaper to pay for these things now, rather than wait until your pet has Lyme Disease, Heartworm, or a much more serious medical problem. If you do have to buy medications every few months, buying online through a site like 1800PetMeds.com can save you loads of cash. Or you can print out the price sheet and see if your vet will match the price. More than likely they will, and you'll avoid extra shipping costs!

Another option to consider is pet insurance. It might seem silly to pay \$18-\$20 a month on insurance that you may or may not use, but if you're concerned about an expensive vet bill down the road that you might not be